
MiniLicensePlates.com

Complete specification for building the site from scratch

Master Build Prompt

Copy Section 0 (opening instruction) plus all sections into an AI coding session.
May 2026 Â· Technical reference

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0. Opening Instruction

Paste this paragraph first when starting a new AI session to rebuild the site:

Build MiniLicensePlates.com from scratch exactly as specified in this document. This is a Laravel 12 + MySQL + Blade application for collectors of miniature license plate premiums (cereal/gum/candy toys). Implement all features, migrations, routes, views, CSS, admin CMS, member tools, and deploy scaffolding described here. Do not use SQLite, Vite, or React. Do not commit public/plates/ or mlp_code/ to git. Build phase by phase; match the visual design and behavior precisely.

1. Project Mission

Site: MiniLicensePlates.com (minilicenseplates.com)

Audience: Collectors of miniature license plates issued as product premiums.

Goals

- Authoritative visual reference and pricing guide for 3,150+ catalog listings
- Searchable database (not filesystem scan) with plate photos on disk
- Member accounts to track collections and print PDF checklists
- Admin CMS for catalog, content, users, and homepage hero
- History timeline and articles for SEO and engagement
- Newsletter signup; Google AdSense-ready ad slots; future on-site store in copy
- Tone: warm, authoritative, collector-focused

Round displayed catalog count to nearest 50 on marketing copy (e.g. 3,118 â†’ 3,150+).

2. Tech Stack & Constraints

- Laravel 12, PHP 8.2+, **MySQL only** (local DB: minilicenseplates)
- Blade views ONLY in resources/views/ (no raw .php view files)
- Single CSS: public/main.css (no Vite/build step)
- Sessions, cache, queue: database drivers
- Local: XAMPP MySQL + `php artisan serve` at `http://localhost:8000`
- Git ignore: public/plates/, mlp_code/, .env
- Commits via GitHub Desktop (document; avoid Cursor git lock issues)

Production hosting

- App: `/home/minilp/laravel/`
- Web root: `/home/minilp/public_html/` (sibling, NOT laravel/public)
- `public_html/index.php` bootstraps `../laravel`
- **WebPublicPath** helper: use sibling `public_html` when present; else `public_path()` locally
- Deploy: `Build-DeployRelease.ps1` + FileZilla; docs/DEPLOY_PLAIN_ENGLISH.md

3. Visual Design System

CSS variable `--site-max-width: 1150px`. Colors: nav #4079a5, links #fab95b.

Global layout

- Tiled background: `background_img.jpg`
- White content column 1150px max, ~4px side/bottom margin
- Split header banners (175px max height), left/right anchored
- Footer inside white box: `footer_base_img.png`, logos, newsletter, copyright bar

Navigation

HOME | GALLERY | SEARCH | HISTORY | ARTICLES | MORE $\hat{=}$ 3/4 | MY COLLECTION or SIGN IN | SHOP (eBay external). MORE hover dropdown: About, Contribute. Session bar: avatar, $\hat{=}$ Logged in as {username} $\hat{=}$ ☐, admin link, Log out. No collection link in session bar.

Home page

- Hero rotator (DB slides, `home-hero.js`, flush to top)
- Welcome, H1, stat block, mission + composite image
- Three feature cards with bottom-aligned CTAs $\hat{=}$ gallery, search, collection
- `brands.jpg` on wheat/orange band

Search (/search)

- Filters: year, jurisdiction, set name, company, set types m/c/s/x
- Grid (3-col) and list toggle; 12 per page; custom pagination << >>
- Orange 2px pricing borders; `plate_missing.png` fallback
- 728 $\hat{=}$ 90 ad placeholders above/below results
- Collapsible search form when results shown

Gallery

- Index: 4-across set cards, random thumb, set name, company, set code, cat ref
- Show: 4-col grid, hover flip `_a/_b`, jurisdiction + variety labels, preload backs

History, Articles, About, Contribute

- History: vertical accordion, 60 $\hat{=}$ 60 thumbs, wheat labels, justified body text
- Articles: published only; keyword search with highlight in title and body
- About: `proheadshot.jpg`; Contribute: honeypot + email

4. Routes

PUBLIC

```
GET / home
GET /ads.txt AdSense verification
GET /gallery gallery.index
GET /gallery/{setName} gallery.show
GET /search search
GET /sitemap.xml sitemap
GET /about, /history, /articles, /articles/{slug}
GET/POST /contribute, POST /newsletter/subscribe
```

GUEST: /login, /register

AUTH + not.blocked:

```
/profile, /collection, /collection/manage, /collection/manage/pdf
/collection/manage/fill, /collection/{item}/edit|update|destroy
/collection/sets/{setCode}/visibility
/collection/members/{username}
```

AUTH + admin (/admin):

dashboard, users, newsletter, home-hero, history-timeline, articles, catalog (sets, plates, CSV import)

POST /logout

5. Database Schema

plates

Catalog pricing guide. Unique (set_code, image_base, variety_key).

Columns	Notes
set_code, set_name, cat_ref, company	Identification
image_base, image_ext, has_back_image	Nullable = no photo
jurisdiction, jurisdiction_type	us_state, ca_province, ca_territory, foreign_country
year, serial_number, width_inches, height_inches	Metadata
value_mt € value_po	Six condition values
variety_key, variety_notes, state_embossed, legend_embossed, notes, sort_order	Variety & display

Other tables

Table	Purpose
users	+ username, phone, address, profile_image, is_admin, is_blocked
collection_items	user_id, plate_id, qty, condition, notes, is_wanted
collection_set_settings	user_id, set_code, is_public
newsletter_subscribers	email, subscribed_at
hero_settings, hero_slides	Rotator config + slides (fill_slide option)
history_timeline_entries	Accordion content + images
articles, article_images	Editorial content, draft/publish

6. Data Import & Images

CSV import

`php artisan plates:import [csv] [--truncate]` â€” default: docs/Mini Plate Checklist - all_plates.csv. Map `image_A` â†’ `image_base`; `jurisdiction_type` aliases; duplicate keys get -2, -3 suffix on `variety_key`.

File paths (NOT in git)

```
{WebPublicPath}/plates/{set_code}/{image_base}_a.{ext}
{WebPublicPath}/plates/{set_code}/{image_base}_b.{ext}
Also: hero/, history-media/, articles-media/, plate_missing.png
```

Image optimization

`php artisan images:optimize plates|all [--set=code] [--dry-run]` â€” GD profiles for plate, hero, history, article, profile. Optimize on admin upload.

7. Member Collection Features

- **/collection** â€” sets owned, public/private toggle, browse other public collectors
- **/collection/manage** â€” editable set table, fill-set defaults, private valuation total
- **PDF export** â€” letter-size checklist via dompdf
- **/profile** â€” phone, address, photo with live preview
- Blocked users cannot access member routes

8. Admin CMS

Module	Capabilities
Users	Block, admin flag, delete
Newsletter	List, delete subscribers
Home hero	Slides CRUD, interval, fill_slide
History	Timeline CRUD, image upload, delete confirm
Articles	CRUD, publish action, images
Catalog	Sets/plates CRUD, CSV import + template, plate image upload

9. SEO & Advertising

- Per-page title, meta_description, canonical_url
- JSON-LD WebSite schema on home
- Dynamic sitemap.xml
- config/adsense.php + GET /ads.txt
- 728Ã—90 placeholders on search results

10. Layout & Blade Structure

layouts/app.blade.php (minimal @if usage), components/header, footer, home-hero-rotator, search/*, views for all pages listed in Section 4, admin/*, auth/*, collection/pdf/set-checklist.blade.php.

11. Key Business Rules

- plates = pricing guide, not physical inventory
- serial_number = text ON the plate; cat_ref = catalog reference
- NULL image_base â†’ plate_missing.png
- Set type filter: first letter of set_code (m/c/s/x)
- Gallery sort: year, set_code. Search sort: set_name, sort_order, jurisdiction

12. Deploy & Operations

Create: `deploy.config.json`, `Build-DeployRelease.ps1`, `public_html-index.php`, `site-check.php`, `DEPLOY_PLAIN_ENGLISH.md`, `PLATE_CSV_COLUMNS_REFERENCE.html`, `GALLERY_CATALOG_SPEC.md`, `PROJECT_REFERENCE.md`.

Production DB: `minilp_minilp`. After deploy: `migrate --force`, clear view cache. AWS CDN documented but optional.

13. Implementation Order

Phase	Scope
1	Layout, CSS, home, about, contribute
2	plates migration + CSV import
3	Gallery + Search
4	Auth, collection, PDF
5	Admin catalog + users
6	Hero, history, articles CMS
7	Newsletter, SEO, AdSense, image optimizer
8	Deploy scripts + docs

14. Definition of Done

A fresh clone with MySQL, migrations, `plates:import`, and `public/plates/` populated produces a site matching `minilicenseplates.com` in function and layout: same routes, member/admin features, search/gallery behavior, CMS modules, deploy model, and gitignore rules.

Do not simplify search UI, remove collection PDF/valuation, or commit plate binaries to git.

Appendix — Complete Verbatim Prompt

Copy everything in the box below into an AI coding session (includes all 14 sections in full detail).

Build MinilicensePlates.com from scratch exactly as specified below. This is a Laravel 12 + MySQL + Blade application for collectors of miniature license plate premiums (cereal/gum/candy toys). Implement all features, migrations, routes, views, CSS, admin CMS, member tools, and deploy scaffolding described here. Do not use SQLite, Vite, or React. Do not commit public/plates/ or mlp_code/ to git.

1. PROJECT MISSION

Site: MinilicensePlates.com (minilicenseplates.com)

Audience: Collectors of miniature license plates issued as product premiums.

Goals:

- Authoritative visual reference and pricing guide for 3,150+ catalog listings
- Searchable database (not filesystem scan) with plate photos on disk
- Member accounts to track personal collections and print PDF checklists
- Admin CMS for catalog, content, users, and homepage hero
- History timeline and articles for SEO and engagement
- Newsletter signup; Google AdSense-ready ad slots; future on-site store mentioned in copy
- Tone: warm, authoritative, collector-focused

Round displayed catalog count to nearest 50 on marketing copy (e.g. 3,118 â€™ 3,150+).

2. TECH STACK & CONSTRAINTS

- Laravel 12, PHP 8.2+, MySQL only (database name: minilicenseplates locally)
- Blade views ONLY in resources/views/ (no raw .php view files)
- Single CSS file: public/main.css (no Vite/build step)
- Sessions, cache, queue: database drivers
- Local dev: XAMPP MySQL + php artisan serve at http://localhost:8000
- .env: DB_USERNAME=root, DB_PASSWORD= empty for local XAMPP
- Git ignore: public/plates/, mlp_code/, .env
- Use GitHub Desktop for commits (document this; do not rely on Cursor git)

Production hosting layout:

- Application: /home/minilp/laravel/
- Public web root: /home/minilp/public_html/ (sibling folder, NOT laravel/public)
- public_html/index.php bootstraps ../laravel
- WebPublicPath helper: if sibling public_html exists with index.php, use it for uploads and image paths; else use public_path() for local dev
- Deploy: PowerShell script Build-DeployRelease.ps1 packages laravel/ + public_html/ for FileZilla upload; docs/DEPLOY_PLAIN_ENGLISH.md for step-by-step owner instructions

3. VISUAL DESIGN SYSTEM (public/main.css)

CSS variable --site-max-width: 1150px for white content column.

Page:

- Tiled background: public/background_img.jpg (repeat)
- White content box centered, max-width 1150px, ~4px margin at sides/bottom so background shows

Header:

- Split banners: public/header_banner_left.png + header_banner_right.png
- Flex layout, left/right anchored, max-height 175px, object-fit contain
- Header width matches content column

Navigation:

- Background #4079a5
- Link text #fab95b, Open Sans bold (or closest Google Font), ~20% smaller than initial draft so all links fit one line
- White border around nav block, square corners (no border-radius)
- Items: HOME | GALLERY | SEARCH | HISTORY | ARTICLES | MORE (dropdown) | MY COLLECTION or SIGN IN | SHOP (external eBay

link)

- MORE dropdown: hover-only (not always visible); About, Contribute; left-aligned links, 8px padding
- HISTORY and ARTICLES are top-level nav links, NOT inside MORE

Logged-in session bar (below nav, inside nav block):

- Profile thumbnail + "Logged in as {username}" (links to profile edit only â€” NOT to collection)
- If is_admin: "admin" text link to /admin
- "Log out" button to the right
- Do NOT show "My Collection" link here (nav already has MY COLLECTION)

Footer:

- Based on footer_base_img.png with alpca_logo.png, avatar.png
- Placeholder link columns left/right for future pages
- Copyright bar in light shade matching footer art
- Newsletter: email input + submit; validate email; store in newsletter_subscribers with subscribed_at timestamp
- Footer sits inside white content box with small margin matching sides

Home page sections:

- Hero rotator flush to top (no gap above): admin-managed slides from DB, JS rotator (public/js/home-hero.js), configurable interval
- Welcome: "MinilicensePlates.com" semi-bold, 10% larger
- H1 + lead paragraph about visual reference to mini plates from 1930sâ€”today
- Stat block: "{count}+ subjects in the catalog"
- Mission section with blue_back_composite_img_sm.jpg on right
- Copy mentions: history section, printable checklists, upcoming store on this website
- Three feature cards (Set Gallery, Catalog Search, Printable Checklists) with CTAs bottom-aligned inside each card:
 - Browse set images â†’ /gallery
 - Catalog search â†’ /search
 - My Collection link â†’ /collection (auth) or login
- brands.jpg on wheat/orange band below feature cards, widened to ~5px from white box edges, no border on orange box

Search page:

- Breadcrumbs + half-width left column: breadcrumbs, "Search the catalog" title, intro text, red ****NOTE:**** disclaimer
- Right half: notice box (when designed)
- Search form: year, jurisdiction (label: "Jurisdiction (state/prov/country)"), set name, company, set type checkboxes (m/c/s/x)
- Form hides when results show; "Try another search" toggles visibility; intro text inside show/hide
- 728x90 gray (#777) ad placeholder above and below results (white centered text "728x90 banner advertisement")
- Grid view: 3 columns, gray card background, black border removed, plate image in same card as info, orange 2px pricing table borders, pricing anchored above two dark blue buttons, empty placeholder cells if row has fewer than 3
- List view: full-width rows, image left in black-padded box, info + pricing + buttons right; list text 15% larger; 10px margin right of buttons; pricing table same height as buttons; orange 2px borders; centered table text
- Toggle grid/list; pagination 12 per page; custom pagination with << (to page 2 when page 1 hidden) and >> (to last page when last hidden)
- plate_missing.png when no image

Gallery index (/gallery):

- Title/breadcrumb: "Gallery" / "Browse set images"
- 4-across set cards, gray background, black border matching search cards
- Random front image from set folder per card
- Set name, company (smaller), set code line, cat ref line ("ref: {value}" salmon color, or unknown)
- Aligned text rows across cards (fixed image div height ~180px)

Gallery show (/gallery/{setName}):

- setName is URL-encoded set_name from DB
- Header row: set title left, small "Return to Gallery" button right (same line)
- 4-column image grid, larger images
- Each cell: gray background, image in black box with 10px pad, jurisdiction centered below image in small text, variety in parentheses after jurisdiction
- Hover: flip front (_a) to back (_b); preload back images on page load
- Match image files to DB via image_base + jurisdiction logic (resolveSetImageDirectory, collectSetImages)

History (/history):

- Vertical accordion (NOT hover modals) â€” expand/collapse sections
- Each entry: 60x60 circular thumb (zoomed crop of image), wheat-colored label row (bold white text on colored background), expandable body
- Body: justified serif text (readable font), paragraph indent, single blank line between paragraphs
- Image floated right ~50% modal width with black background + light gray italic caption beneath image
- Click outside accordion panel does NOT close (accordion behavior only)
- Data from history_timeline_entries table; seed from config on first migration if empty

Articles (/articles, /articles/{slug}):

- List published articles only; keyword search with highlighted terms in titles AND body (use mark/highlight class)
- Fields: author, title, subtitle, slug, body, hero image, multiple article_images with alt/caption/sort_order
- Draft vs published: is_published + published_at; admin must click Publish to go live

About: owner proheadshot.jpg with site story

Contribute: contact form, honeypot field "company", email to site owner

4. ROUTES (routes/web.php)

Public:

```
GET / home
GET /ads.txt AdSense ads.txt line from config
GET /gallery gallery.index
GET /gallery/{setName} gallery.show
GET /search search
GET /sitemap.xml dynamic sitemap
GET /about about
GET /history history
GET /articles articles.index
GET /articles/{slug} articles.show
GET /contribute contribute
POST /contribute contribute.store
POST /newsletter/subscribe newsletter.subscribe
```

Guest:

```
GET/POST /login, /register
```

Auth + not.blocked:

```
GET /profile, PUT /profile
GET /collection
POST /collection
GET /collection/manage
PUT /collection/manage
POST /collection/manage/fill
GET /collection/manage/pdf
GET /collection/{item}/edit
PUT /collection/{item}
DELETE /collection/{item}
PUT /collection/sets/{setCode}/visibility
GET /collection/members/{username}
```

Auth + not.blocked + admin (/admin):

- dashboard, users CRUD, newsletter list/delete
- home-hero: settings, slides CRUD, fill_slide option
- history-timeline CRUD + delete with confirmation
- articles CRUD + publish action
- catalog: sets CRUD, plates CRUD, CSV import + template download

```
POST /logout (auth)
```

Middleware:

- EnsureUserIsAdmin (admin)
- EnsureUserIsNotBlocked (not.blocked)

5. DATABASE SCHEMA (migrations)

plates â€” catalog pricing guide, one row per plate type/variety:

```
id, set_code(64), set_name(255), cat_ref(10)?, company(128)?,
image_base(128)?, image_ext(16)?, has_back_image(tinyint)?,
jurisdiction(128)?, jurisdiction_type(32)? â€” us_state|ca_province|ca_territory|foreign_country,
year(int)?, serial_number(64)?, width_inches/height_inches decimal(10,4)?,
value_mt, value_ex, value_vg, value_g, value_fr, value_po (varchar 32)?,
variety_key(32)?, variety_notes(text)?, state_embossed/legend_embossed(tinyint)?,
notes(text)?, sort_order(int default 0), timestamps
UNIQUE(set_code, image_base, variety_key)
Indexes on set_code, jurisdiction, year, company, cat_ref, etc.
```


users â€” Laravel default + username(30 unique), phone, address, profile_image, is_admin, is_blocked, blocked_at, blocked_reason
 Bootstrap admin: config admin.bootstrap_email promoted on migration

collection_items:
 user_id, plate_id, quantity, condition(4 chars MT/EX/VG/G/FR/PO),
 acquired_date, price_paid, storage_location, notes, is_wanted
 UNIQUE(user_id, plate_id)

collection_set_settings:
 user_id, set_code, is_public boolean

newsletter_subscribers:
 email unique, subscribed_at

hero_settings: interval_ms (default 7000)
 hero_slides: sort_order, image, alt, headline, subtitle, cta, route, route_params(json), bg, is_active, fill_slide

history_timeline_entries:
 slug, sort_order, label, title, body, image, alt, caption, is_published

articles: slug, author, title, subtitle, body, hero_image, hero_image_alt, sort_order, is_published, published_at
 article_images: article_id, image_path, alt, caption, sort_order

Standard Laravel: sessions, cache, jobs, password_reset_tokens tables.

=====

6. DATA IMPORT & IMAGES

=====

Artisan command: php artisan plates:import [csv_path] [--truncate]
 - Default CSV: docs/Mini Plate Checklist - all_plates.csv
 - Map image_A typo column â†’ image_base
 - Map jurisdiction_type: canadaâ†’ca_province, foreign/territoryâ†’foreign_country
 - Empty image_base â†’ nophoto-{rowNum}; empty variety_key â†’ base
 - Duplicate unique key â†’ append -2, -3 to variety_key

Plate images on disk (NOT in git):
 {WebPublicPath}/plates/{set_code}/{image_base}_a.{ext}
 {WebPublicPath}/plates/{set_code}/{image_base}_b.{ext} (optional back)

Other media folders under WebPublicPath:
 hero/, history-media/, articles-media/, profile uploads
 plate_missing.png, header banners, background, footer assets, setinfo/

Display dimensions: if width/height < 1 inch, show without leading zero (.625 not 0.625)

Image optimization (GD):
 - ImageOptimizer class with profiles: plate, hero, history, article, profile
 - Artisan: php artisan images:optimize {plates|articles-media|history-media|hero|all} [--set=code] [--dry-run]
 - Default target: plates; dry-run shows folder path + count only (not file list)
 - Optimize on upload in admin for hero, history, articles, profile, catalog plate uploads

Article images: use stable filenames (e.g. variety-post.jpg) not random hashes in public URL

=====

7. MEMBER COLLECTION FEATURES

=====

/collection index:
 - Abbreviated list of sets user has entered data for
 - Link to manage each set
 - Per-set public/private toggle (collection_set_settings)
 - Section: other members' public collections â€” username link, total quantity owned

/collection/manage:
 - Pick set by search/dropdown
 - Full set as editable table: quantity, condition, notes, wanted flag, etc.
 - "Fill set" action: default quantity + condition applied to all plates in set
 - Show catalog value for user's chosen condition (private total)
 - PDF export: letter-size checklist (full set or user's owned items only) via dompdf

/collection/members/{username}:

- View another user's public set data; display @username correctly in Blade (escape @ as @@)

Profile /profile:

- Edit name, email, username, phone, address, profile photo upload
- Live preview on file select before save
- Clear label for remove-photo checkbox (plain language)

Registration/login: username required, unique; blocked users cannot access member routes

8. ADMIN CMS

Dashboard linking to all modules.

Users: list, view, block/unblock with reason, grant is_admin, delete

Newsletter: list subscribers, delete

Home hero: edit rotation interval; CRUD slides with image upload, headline, subline, CTA, route link, background color/gradient, fill_slide checkbox for full-bleed image

History timeline: CRUD, image upload to history-media/, caption, sort order, delete with JS confirm

Articles: CRUD, multiple image uploads, draft/publish button sets is_published + published_at

Catalog:

- Sets index with compact row height (5px vertical padding on text)
- Add set form: centered 700px box; row1 set_code (~8 chars wide input) + set_name (~35 chars); row2 year (~5 chars) + company (~45 chars); spacing above submit button
- Set show: plate list, edit/delete
- Plate create/edit: all plate columns, image upload to plates/{set_code}/
- CSV import page: download template matching plates schema, upload CSV for bulk insert into one set

Catalog set form and import follow docs/PLATE_CSV_COLUMNS_REFERENCE.html column definitions.

9. SEO & ADS

layouts/app.blade.php:

- @yield title, meta_description, canonical_url
- JSON-LD structured data where appropriate (WebSite on home)
- AdSense script partial when config enabled

SitemapController: include home, gallery, search, history, articles, about, published article URLs

Home page: keyword-rich but readable prose; dynamic plate count in meta

config/adsense.php: publisher ID, enable flag

GET /ads.txt â†’ google.com, pub-{id}, DIRECT, f08c47fec0942fa0

Search results: 728Ã–90 placeholder components (real ad units later)

10. LAYOUT & BLADE STRUCTURE

resources/views/layouts/app.blade.php â€” minimal head, no complex unclosed @if components/header.blade.php, footer.blade.php

components/home-hero-rotator.blade.php

components/search/*, components/ads/* as needed

views: home, about, history, contribute, search, gallery/index, gallery/show

views: articles/index, articles/show

views: collection/*, profile/edit

views: admin/* for all CMS modules

views: auth/login, register

PDF view: collection/pdf/set-checklist.blade.php

Keep layout simple to avoid Blade parse errors.

11. KEY BUSINESS RULES

- plates table is a PRICING GUIDE (six condition columns), not inventory of physical objects
- serial_number = characters printed ON the plate, not catalog ID
- cat_ref = catalog reference number (varchar 10)
- company = issuer/manufacture (Post, General Mills, Topps, etc.)
- Many plates have NULL image_base = no photo; show plate_missing.png
- has_back_image: 1 = back exists at {base}_b.{ext}, 0 = front only, NULL = unknown
- Search set types: first letter of set_code â€” m=metal, c=cards, s=stickers, x=anything else (multi-select OR)
- Gallery sorted by MIN(year), set_code
- Search results sorted by set_name, sort_order, jurisdiction
- Contribute emails: cdcoppercoins@gmail.com (configurable)
- External shop link: <https://www.ebay.com/str/minilicenseplates>

12. DEPLOY & OPS ARTIFACTS

Create:

- deploy/deploy.config.json
- scripts/Build-DeployRelease.ps1
- deploy/public_html-index.php (points to ../laravel)
- deploy/site-check.php, setup-storage-link.php
- docs/DEPLOY_PLAIN_ENGLISH.md (one step at a time for non-technical owner)
- docs/PLATE_CSV_COLUMNS_REFERENCE.html
- GALLERY_CATALOG_SPEC.md, PROJECT_REFERENCE.md, AGENTS.md

Production .env: APP_ENV=production, DB credentials for minilp_minilp on server

After deploy: php artisan migrate --force; clear storage/framework/views/*.php

Promote admin on production via DB or bootstrap email config

Planned but not required for v1 launch: AWS S3/CloudFront (document in docs/AWS_IMAGES_SETUP.md)

13. IMPLEMENTATION ORDER

- Phase 1: Laravel skeleton, layout/CSS, home, about, contribute, static assets
- Phase 2: plates migration + import command + seed from CSV
- Phase 3: Gallery (DB-driven) + Search (grid/list/pagination)
- Phase 4: Auth, profile, collection tracker, PDF, public member browse
- Phase 5: Admin users + catalog CRUD + CSV import
- Phase 6: Hero rotator admin, history accordion + CMS, articles + CMS
- Phase 7: Newsletter, SEO sitemap, AdSense hooks, image optimizer command
- Phase 8: Deploy scripts + documentation

Build each phase completely before moving on. Match visual design precisely. Test on localhost:8000 with XAMPP MySQL.

14. DEFINITION OF DONE

A fresh clone with MySQL running, migrations, plates:import, and public/plates/ folders populated should produce a site indistinguishable in function and layout from minilicenseplates.com as described above: same routes, same member/admin capabilities, same search/gallery behavior, same admin CMS modules, same deploy model, same gitignore rules.

Do not add features not listed unless needed for correctness. Do not simplify the search UI or remove collection valuation/PDF. Do not put plate binary files in git.